PANAVERSITY CERTIFIED ASSOCIATE · FOUNDATIONS

PCAO-F Scenario Practice & Course Review

Six exam-style scenarios with the reasoning behind every option, followed by a structured review of five core courses.

Prepared by the AI Mentor Team

COURSE **Governance, Risk & Responsible Use**

Q1 · D6 · 15%

An automated workflow posts a confidential internal file to a company-wide chat channel. The operations manager has five actions to take. In which order should she take them?

1. Report the incident to security leadership.
2. Carry out the clean-up steps the incident owner assigns.
3. Revoke access to the file and lock the channel.
4. Give the investigators a factual account of what happened.
5. Note the timestamp, file name and channel affected.

A 1 → 3 → 5 → 2 → 4

B 3 → 1 → 5 → 2 → 4

C 5 → 3 → 1 → 4 → 2

D 3 → 5 → 1 → 4 → 2

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q1 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 6 — GOVERNANCE

Correct: D

A **1 → 3 → 5 → 2 → 4**
report → stop → record → clean up → brief

Wrong — reports before stopping the spread. While she phones security, the channel stays open and more people open the file.
Concept: step one is always stop the spread

B **3 → 1 → 5 → 2 → 4**
stop → report → record → clean up → brief

Wrong — two slips. It reports before the facts are written down, and acts on clean-up before giving investigators the facts.
Concept: record → report → state facts → follow the owner

C **5 → 3 → 1 → 4 → 2**
record → stop → report → brief → clean up

Wrong — the tempting one. Noting details feels urgent, but the file is still spreading. Lock it first; the notes can wait a minute.
Concept: containment before documentation

D **3 → 5 → 1 → 4 → 2**
stop → record → report → brief → clean up

Correct. Contain it, capture the facts while they're exact, report promptly, state them plainly, then act on the owner's instructions.
Concept: the first-hour procedure, in order

CONCEPT TESTED — THE FIRST HOUR

Stop the spread → record facts → report → state plainly → follow the incident owner. Source — *Governance, Risk & Responsible Use* §7. Never delete to hide it.

COURSE **Just Delegate It · AI Fluency**

Q2 · D1 · 14%

An operations manager wants an AI assistant's help choosing between two vendor proposals. Her choice goes to her director next week. Which request is the best way to hand over this work?

A Attach both proposals and her scoring criteria, and ask for a side-by-side table naming the proposal section behind each figure and flagging anything neither proposal states.

B Attach both proposals and ask which vendor is stronger, leaving the assistant free to weigh whichever factors it judges most relevant to a business like hers.

C Attach both proposals and her scoring criteria, and ask for a finished recommendation memo she can forward to the director without needing to review it first.

D Paste the one-paragraph summary she wrote of each proposal plus her scoring criteria, and ask for a scored comparison table ending in a recommendation.

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q2 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 1 — PROMPTING & TASK EXECUTION

Correct: A

A	Proposals + her criteria → side-by-side table naming the section behind each figure, flagging what neither states.	**Correct.** Real sources, her criteria, a checkable deliverable and room to say "not stated". The decision stays with her. Concept: the full Delegation Brief
B	Proposals only → "which is stronger?", AI weighs whatever factors it judges relevant.	**Wrong — no criteria.** The AI guesses what matters to her, then delivers a confident pick she can't check against her priorities. Concept: under-specification (Description)
C	Proposals + criteria → a finished memo to forward without reviewing it.	**Wrong — the strong distractor.** The inputs are right, but "no review" deletes the Verification line and hands over the decision. Her name is still on it. Concept: Authority + Verification · accountability stays
D	Her own one-paragraph summaries + criteria → scored table with a recommendation.	**Wrong — the subtle one.** Her summaries replace the proposals. Anything she left out is invisible, and nothing traces back to the real documents. Concept: give the source, stay inside it

CONCEPT TESTED — THE DELEGATION BRIEF

Outcome · Context · Constraints · Authority · Deliverable · Verification. Each wrong option breaks one line. Source — *Just Delegate It* §3, §5 · *AI Fluency* (Description).

COURSE **Just Delegate It · Workflow Design & Diagnosis**

Q3 · D4 · 16%

In testing, an AI assistant reviewing branch compliance logs invented missing applicant IDs, granted policy exceptions on its own and auto-approved flagged documents. The manager will set firm limits in the prompt for a standard report. Which instruction set should she use?

A Fixed report layout; infer any missing applicant ID from nearby records; route policy exceptions to a named reviewer; approve flagged documents below a set risk score.

B Free-form narrative summary; mark missing applicant IDs “unverified”; approve exceptions that match an earlier precedent; never approve a flagged document.

C Fixed report layout; mark missing applicant IDs “unverified”; route policy exceptions to a named reviewer; never approve a flagged document.

D Fixed report layout; mark missing applicant IDs “unverified”; approve exceptions that match an earlier precedent; approve flagged documents below a set risk score.

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q3 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 4 — WORKFLOW INTEGRATION & DESIGN

Correct: C

A — Fixed layout · infer missing IDs · exceptions → named reviewer · approve flagged below a risk score

Wrong on two clauses. "Infer" an ID is inventing it with extra steps. A threshold still lets AI approve flagged items.

Concept: mark unverified — never fill gaps

B — Free-form narrative · IDs unverified · approve exceptions by precedent · never approve flagged

Wrong on two clauses. A narrative breaks the standard report, and "by precedent" still lets AI grant exceptions — a person's call.

Concept: product description · human-retained step

C — Fixed layout · IDs unverified · exceptions → named reviewer · never approve flagged

Correct. Every boundary holds: a set format, no invented data, a defined gate for exceptions, no auto-approval.

Concept: authority set in the brief

D — Fixed layout · IDs unverified · exceptions by precedent · approve flagged below a risk score

Wrong — sounds controlled. Gets the IDs right, then hands AI two decisions. "Below a threshold" is still AI deciding.

Concept: a limit on a decision isn't a gate

CONCEPT TESTED — BOUNDARIES THAT ACTUALLY HOLD

Missing data → "unverified". Exceptions and approvals → a named person. Source — *Just Delegate It* §3, §7 · *Workflow Design* (human-retained steps).

COURSE **AI Fluency · Workflow Design & Diagnosis**

Q4 · D1 · 14%

A property manager uses an AI assistant to choose between three office-lease offers, using written, weighted criteria. In which order should these five activities run?

1. Have the assistant score each offer against the weighted criteria.
2. Have the assistant draft the recommendation for the finance committee.
3. Have the assistant put rent, term, exit terms and fit-out costs into one table.
4. Check several table cells against the original offers.
5. Have the assistant compare the offers using only the table.

A 3 → 5 → 1 → 2 → 4

B 3 → 4 → 5 → 1 → 2

C 3 → 1 → 5 → 2 → 4

D 3 → 5 → 4 → 1 → 2

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q4 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 1 — PROMPTING & TASK EXECUTION

Correct: B

A **3 → 5 → 1 → 2 → 4**
table → compare → score → draft → check

Wrong — checks at the very end. One wrong rent figure has already flowed into the comparison, the scores and the memo.
Concept: errors spread from the first step

B **3 → 4 → 5 → 1 → 2**
table → check → compare → score → draft

Correct. Check the extraction before anything builds on it, then compare, score from the comparison, and draft last.
Concept: split by order, check between steps

C **3 → 1 → 5 → 2 → 4**
table → score → compare → draft → check

Wrong — two slips. Scores before comparing (scores come from the comparison), and leaves the only check until after the draft.
Concept: each step uses the one before it

D **3 → 5 → 4 → 1 → 2**
table → compare → check → score → draft

Wrong — the subtle one. It does check — but only after the comparison has already used the table. Too late for that step.
Concept: check before the next step builds on it

CONCEPT TESTED — PROCESS DESCRIPTION

Extraction first, checked first — a wrong figure there carries through everything. Source — *AI Fluency* §4.2 · *Workflow Design* (verify before you build).

A marketer asks for five campaign concepts with a tight brief: exact tagline, a required three-part structure, strict tone, a 40-word cap. He gets five near-identical ideas. He adds more detail and asks for twenty — still neighbours of one idea. Best next move?

A Add two strong example concepts to the brief, so the model has a clearer picture of what a winning idea looks like.

B Switch to the most capable model tier, since a stronger model should find more original angles in the same brief.

C Ask for fifty concepts instead of twenty, then shortlist the few that are genuinely different from the rest.

D Keep the product, audience and what to avoid, but drop the format rules until one direction is chosen.

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q5 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 1 — PROMPTING & TASK EXECUTION

Correct: D

A	Add two strong example concepts so the model sees what a winner looks like.	**Wrong — more grip, not less.** Examples anchor the model even harder; you get variations on your two examples. Concept: tight shape → rewordings of one idea
B	Switch to the most capable model tier for more original angles.	**Wrong — not a capability problem.** Any tier returns near-copies when the brief has pinned the shape shut. Concept: diagnose before you escalate
C	Ask for fifty instead of twenty, then shortlist the different ones.	**Wrong — volume isn't variety.** Twenty already proved it: more of the same brief means more neighbours. Concept: change the brief, not the count
D	Keep product, audience and what to avoid; drop the format rules until a direction is chosen.	**Correct.** Keep the full situation, loosen the shape of the answer to open up options, then tighten again to build the winner. Concept: the grip dial — loose for options

CONCEPT TESTED — MATCH THE GRIP TO THE ASK

Situation: always full. Output shape: loose for brainstorming, tight for drafting. Source — *AI Prompting in 2026*, "One loop, four kinds of ask".

A clinic administrator wants to know whether an AI assistant can reliably take over her weekly patient-intake summary. Before trusting it with anything live, she tests it. In which order should she carry out these five actions?

1. Compare the assistant's output with the result she already knows is correct.
2. Have the assistant reproduce the case from the context she would normally have had.
3. Pick one recurring task and define it precisely.
4. Refine the instructions and run it again, or decide the task stays human.
5. Give the assistant a past case whose correct answer she already holds.

A 3 → 5 → 2 → 1 → 4

B 3 → 5 → 2 → 4 → 1

C 5 → 3 → 2 → 1 → 4

D 5 → 3 → 2 → 4 → 1

Pick one — 60 seconds.

Q6 · ANSWER · DOMAIN 2 — OUTPUT EVALUATION (21%)

Correct: A

A **3 → 5 → 2 → 1 → 4**
define → give case → reproduce → compare → refine

Correct. Define the task, pick a case that matches it, let the AI reproduce it, compare with the known answer, then improve — or keep it human.
Concept: prove it on work you already know

B **3 → 5 → 2 → 4 → 1**
define → give case → reproduce → refine → compare

Wrong — refines blind. She can't know what to fix until she has compared the output with the known answer.
Concept: compare against known truth first

C **5 → 3 → 2 → 1 → 4**
give case → define → reproduce → compare → refine

Wrong — case before task. Without a precise task definition first, she can't pick a case that tests the right thing.
Concept: be precise about the task first

D **5 → 3 → 2 → 4 → 1**
give case → define → reproduce → refine → compare

Wrong — both slips. The case comes before the task, and refining comes before comparing.
Concept: define → test → compare → refine

CONCEPT TESTED — EARNED TRUST

Passing earns confidence for similar work — it never transfers accountability. Source — *ChatGPT & Claude Quick Reference* §9 · *Just Delegate It* §10.

6 SCENARIOS · ONE JUDGMENT LAYER

What the six really tested

Q1 · Incident — Stop the spread, record, then report. Clean-up last.

Q2 · Briefing — Real sources, your criteria, a checkable deliverable. The decision stays yours.

Q3 · Boundaries — Gaps get marked “unverified”; exceptions and approvals go to a named person.

Q4 · Process — Check each step before the next one builds on it.

Q5 · Grip — Loose shape for options, tight shape for execution.

Q6 · Trust — Earn it on work you already know. It never moves your accountability.

Every wrong answer is **reckless** (blind trust in AI) or **wasteful** (giving up on a task a safe path could do). The right answer finds the middle — and keeps a human accountable.

D4 16% + D7 10% = 26% of the exam

The whole course on one map

“The output is not the verdict.” Decide about the **step** in advance — never judge the **session** by how the result looked.

1 · DESIGN

What are the real requirements — and which numbers must be **computed**, not written?

2 · MAP — D4 core

For each step: can it be undone? what does an error cost? **who answers?**

3 · BUILD

Ideate → prototype → feedback → refine. Once others **depend** on it, hand it to engineering.

4 · DIAGNOSE — D7 core

When it breaks, ask first: **when did the symptom appear?** Then check cheapest-first.

5 · PERSIST

Is the fix a **rule**, a **reference** or a **procedure**? Each has its own home.

6 · COMMUNICATE

Say what it does, then **name the human gate**. Never “fully automated.”

Six stages, in order. **Map** and **Diagnose** carry the exam weight — the next two slides open them up.

Who owns each step? Three questions decide it

Reversibility
Can it be undone if AI gets it wrong?

Stakes
What does an error cost in the **bad** case — not the average one?

Accountability
Is this step **the decision** — or an input someone judges next?

gives one of three owners · where they disagree, the strictest one wins

AI-appropriate
AI owns it. Undoable, and someone judges the output at the next step.

e.g. extract clauses

Collaborative
AI produces, a **named** person judges — who, what, when.

e.g. draft the redline

Human-retained
A person owns it outright: irreversible, or it **is** the decision.

e.g. approve changes · sign & send

Check first — the window test: can everything the step needs be put in front of the model? If not (a hiring freeze said in a meeting), the step is yours.

Not a criterion: how well AI did last time. Good past output never moves a step into AI's column.

When it breaks: ask *when* it started

When the symptom appeared	Likely cause	One-minute check	Fix
Wrong from the first answer	Under-specification	Is the missing thing actually in the prompt?	Add what it left out
Fine, then degraded as the chat grew	Context overload	Restate it in a fresh chat — does it hold?	Restart, or summarise
One repeatable kind of error	Wrong feature / model	Run once with the right feature or tier	Code execution · stronger tier
Used to work, now doesn't	Stale configuration	Check the date of the instruction / file	Update the Project setup

THE DIAGNOSTIC SEQUENCE — CHEAPEST FIRST

1 · Prompt → **2 · Session length** → **3 · Feature & model** → **4 · Configuration** → **5 · Is the task a fit?**

Most people start at 3 or 5 — a bigger model, or “AI can't do this.” Reached first, “not a fit” is an excuse; reached last, it's a conclusion.

Make the fix stick **Rule** → standing instruction · **Reference** → knowledge base · **Procedure** (steps in order) → Skill

Six traps — and how to spot them in a question

Trap	How it sounds in the question	The right move
Halo delegation	“It drafted well for months — let it approve too.”	Drafting quality is evidence about the draft, not the decision. Judge each step alone.
Accountability trap	“The manager is accountable, so drafting must stay human.”	Ask: is this step the decision, or an input someone judges? Inputs can go to AI.
Unstaffed gate	“A human reviews it” — but it's now a glance, then a click.	A real gate names who, what, when. No reviewer = the step is automated.
Under-delegation	“One bad output — AI can't do this task.”	Run the cheapest-first sequence. Usually it was under-specified.
Silent stale config	Perfect format, last month's numbers, no error at all.	Stale setup fails silently — fix the file; re-prompting won't help.
“It's just maths”	“It's arithmetic, so AI can own that step.”	Computing is how a step runs, not who owns it. A key figure still needs a gate.

⚠ Two failures, one mistake: **over-delegating** reads a good output as proof; **under-delegating** reads a bad one as proof. The output is never the verdict.

D6 · 15% of the exam

Four questions, three answers each

Before AI does meaningful work, ask...	Yes	The middle answer	No
1 · The Case — can AI do this work?	Fully appropriate	**With review** — name who, what, when	Inappropriate
2 · The Data — can this information go in?	Green — go	**Yellow** — check first, add a control	Red — not via this route
3 · The Capability — can I turn this on?	Enable	**Escalate** — with the specific question	Decline
4 · The People — unfair to anyone? disclosure?	Decide & document	**Disclose** — rules first, judgment second	Escalate the question

Classify before you act. If the answer is in the middle, name the commitment. A plain yes is reckless; a plain no is wasteful. Accountability never moves to the tool.

Can this information go in? Work it in order

1 · Classify the data tier → **2 · Identifiers or only the pattern?** → **3 · Route** approved for this data & purpose? → **4 · Choose** the control

Green · public, aggregated, truly anonymised → go

Yellow · internal docs, customer / staff IDs, drafts → check first

Red · credentials, health, privileged, secrets → approved route only

Unsure between two? **Pick the higher tier.**

This control...	helps with	does NOT decide
Incognito chat	History & memory (still ~30-day copy)	If the data may go in
“Plan isn't used for training”	Training on your inputs	If this route is approved
Code sandbox	Where code can reach	If the file was authorised
“Don't retain this” in the prompt	Nothing — it's a wish	Anything

Redaction fails two ways

① **Partial** — age + exact date + rare place still re-identify. ② **Breaks the task** — removed what the job needed. And “Customer 17” with the key still held is **pseudonymised**: it keeps its tier.

What you switch on — and who it touches

Capability — can I turn this on?

Five checks before enabling a skill, connector or plugin:

1 Source | 2 Reach | 3 Fit | **4 Outside content** | **5 Actions**

4 + 5 tell you how dangerous a mistake can get.

A skill has no scope dial — it reaches whatever the session reaches.

Internal ≠ vetted. Another team's skill still gets the checks.

Trusted tool ≠ trusted content — prompt injection lives in what it reads.

Escalate with the question, e.g. “it wants write access — can that be narrowed?”

People — who could this affect?

Include people who never see the output. Drivers named in a report count too.

Review the exclusions, not only who AI kept. A shortlist hides who it dropped.

Bias enters through the prompt too — “rank the strongest” carries a hidden standard.

Disclosure: rules first, judgment second. AI notetaker? Announce it at the start.

Escalate the question, not a verdict — send your reasoning, not “can you approve?”

The Governance Record: one workflow, one page

GOVERNANCE RECORD workflow · owner · date

1 · Case
Classification · deciding factor · gate: **who / what / when**

2 · Data
Tier · identifiers needed? · fields removed · **approved route**

3 · Capability
Tools enabled · source & reach · outside content · **actions needing review**

4 · People
Who's affected · **exclusions checked** · disclosure: rule or judgment

5 · Evidence — the block people forget
Success measure · failure threshold · who monitors, how often · **residual risk**

A blank beats a guess

Owner or route unknown? Write **OPEN QUESTION** and send it to whoever can answer.

Residual risk

What can still go wrong **after every control works**. Naming it isn't failure — it lets the owner decide.

Re-check when it changes

Model · feature · data · audience · permission · policy · vendor terms · stakes.

"Approved last year" isn't approval if the thing changed.

Six baits — and the move that beats each

The bait in the question	Why it's wrong — and the right move
“Team plan isn't trained on — just upload it.”	A privacy setting isn't permission. Is this route approved for this data?
“Use incognito / tell it not to retain.”	One is a privacy mode, the other a wish. Neither is a control.
“Names swapped for codes — it's anonymous.”	Key still held = pseudonymised. Check the leftover clues too.
“A human will review it.”	Not a gate until it names who, what, when — before it's hard to undo.
“Another team built it, so it's vetted.”	Internal ≠ vetted. Read it: source, reach, fit.
“Too risky — don't use AI at all.”	Abandonment. Strip identifiers or add a control, then proceed.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG — THE FIRST HOUR

1 Stop the spread → 2 Record facts → 3 Report fast → 4 State plainly → 5 Follow the owner

Never delete the chat to hide it — it removes your visibility, not the data, and turns a mistake into concealment.

D5 · 12% of the exam

Teach it once. Connect it once.

A **chat** says what to do **once**.

A **Skill** teaches **how — every time**. *The recipe card.*

A **Connector** gives AI **hands** to reach your apps. *The kitchen.*

Feature	When it's on	The one-line test
Skill	Sleeps until a request matches — then works anywhere	"I keep re-explaining how."
Connector	When enabled for this chat	"I keep copy-pasting from an app."
Project	Always on inside its workspace	"These files & rules apply to everything here."
Custom instructions	Always on, every chat	"True everywhere, always."

DIAGNOSE BY THE FRICTION

Re-explain **how** → **Skill**

Copy-paste **data** → **Connector**

Both → **both** · One-off → **neither**

Projects store knowledge; Skills perform tasks. A **plugin** bundles skills + connectors for a whole job. A skill earns its place only when the task **repeats your own way**.

A folder, one SKILL.md — and why it fires

L1 · Frontmatter — always loaded

```
name: client-monthly-summary
description: Prepares a monthly client summary. Use
for "client summary", "monthly close".
```

L2 · Instructions — load on a match

```
1. Format amounts…
2. Group by expense head…
```

L3 · Optional folders — only if needed

`references/ · assets/ · scripts/`

This is **progressive disclosure** — why dozens of skills don't slow AI down.

The description is the whole game

AI reads **only the description** to decide. Say **what** it does + **when** + the **exact words** you'd use.

Weak: "Helps with reports." **Sharp:** "…Use for 'monthly close'."

Fires too eagerly? Add a **"Do NOT use for…"** line.

How it starts

Claude.ai: automatic on a match. **Everywhere:** name it — "use my X skill". **Cowork / Office add-ins:** type "/".

Word, PowerPoint, Excel, PDF skills are **built in** — behind "Code execution and file creation".

Build & test

Describe it → **skill-creator** writes it → Save. Test: **does it fire?** · **does it stay out of unrelated asks?** · right output? · hard cases? Debug: ask *"When would you use my X skill — and when not?"*

What it can reach — and where it can go

A connector, in four facts

1 · Inherits your permissions. It reaches only what your account can.

2 · Read-only first. Write = edit, send, delete — a bigger blast radius.

3 · Enabled per chat, scoped small. One folder beats the whole drive.

4 · Can only do what it was built to do. Drive saves new files, can't edit in place. Ask: *"what can't you do?"*

Does it travel to other tools?

SKILL.md — travels. Open standard: Codex CLI, Gemini CLI, Cursor read it. **Setup differs.**

Custom GPT · Gem — locked. Each lives only in its own vendor.

Connectors — everywhere. ChatGPT calls them "apps"; MCP is shared.

Risk 1 · a malicious skill

Hidden instructions, data sent out. **Control: read it before enabling** — trusted sources only.

Risk 2 · over-broad connector

A wrong edit or delete. **Control: read-only start, smallest scope**, check undo first.

Sharing (Team / Enterprise): shared skills are view-only and update when you edit the original; sharing is off until an owner enables it.

Eight baits — and the move that beats each

The bait in the question	Why it's wrong — and the right move
“Set the skill to read-only.”	No scope dial. It reaches whatever the chat reaches — read it first.
“It's only a text file — harmless.”	It steers every connected tool. Hidden instructions can leak data.
“Connecting Drive teaches it our format.”	Connector = access, not method. The format lives in a skill.
“The skill never fires — model's broken.”	Description problem. Add the words you actually say.
“It drifted mid-chat — rewrite the file.”	The file is fine; the chat got long. Start fresh.
“Same error every run — reword it again.”	Move the exact step into a script; guessed data → a connector.
“Grant write access just in case.”	Read-only first, smallest scope, check undo before edits.
“SKILL.md and Custom GPT both just move over.”	SKILL.md travels, setup differs. GPTs and Gems never leave.

Diagnose a skill by timing, like any output: **wrong from reply one** → fix the file · **worse as the chat grows** → fresh chat · **used to work** → the world around it changed.

Feeds D2 (21%) · D1 · D6

Decide · Explain · Check · Own

Automation
AI does a task you specify. **You: script writer.**

Augmentation
You think it through together. **You: co-creator.**

Agency
AI pursues a goal — in the **future**, often **for others**. **You: director.**

→ more freedom for the AI, left to right. No mode is "better" — one project can use all three.

Delegation · decide	**Problem** awareness — goal, risk, success	**Platform** awareness — the right tool	**Task** delegation — who owns each part
Description · explain	**Product** — what you want back	**Process** — how to approach it	**Performance** — how the AI behaves
Discernment · check	**Product** — is the result good?	**Process** — is working this way paying off?	**Performance** — are people served when it acts alone?
Diligence · own	**Creation** — right tool & data	**Transparency** — honest about AI's role	**Deployment** — check before it goes out

Everyone has the same AI. **Fluency** is what you do with it — **effective, efficient, ethical, safe.**

Complete beats clever — then loop

Product — what
Output type, audience, format, length, tone, what to leave out.

Process — how
Split a multi-step job **by order**; check each step. Put **extraction first** — an error there spreads furthest.

Performance — how it behaves
“Challenge me, flag uncertainty.” In a chat it's your preference; in a deployed agent **it is the product.**

At full size, Description = **context engineering**: docs, tools, memory, rules.

THE LOOP

Describe → AI makes → Discern → Refine

The first answer is a draft. Sometimes discernment sends you back to **delegation**.

Feedback: Problem → Why → Direction

Weak: “Wrong. Try again.”

Better: “Section 2 assumes enterprises; we serve solo founders — rewrite for a small budget.”

Every review ends one of three ways

Ready to use · **needs revision** · **take it back**. Name it before the next message.

D2 · 21% — heaviest

Confident is not correct

Automation bias: we trust polished output too easily. A made-up answer usually shows one of four signs —

Too exact
“99.97% on time” from nowhere.

Too certain
A flat yes where experts say “it depends”.

Contradicts itself
Page 2 vs page 6 of a long output.

Claims an action
“I sent it / ran the tests” — no log, no event.

Product
Is the result right, complete — would I sign it?

Process
Is it paying off? 20 min of steering to save 15 is a **loss**.

Performance
Every tutor answer correct — yet students **learn less**.

Judge the justification
A right answer on a wrong assumption won't stay right. Ask for assumptions, evidence, criteria.

Tie it to your documents
“Answer **only** from the attached files. If it isn't stated, **say so**. **Quote** the line it came from.”

AI can automate work — not accountability

Before · Creation
Approved tool? Strip the data to the **pattern**.

During · Transparency
The more it affects people, the more you **disclose**.

After · Deployment
Check deeper as reach grows. Numbers: **computed, never generated**.

The bait	What's missing — and the right move
Typing before deciding what success is.	Delegation. Goal, audience and the human / AI split first.
“First answer was weak — AI can't do this.”	The loop. Problem → why → direction, then retry.
“It sounds professional, so it's right.”	Discernment. Verify facts, numbers and sources.
“The output was great, so the use was fine.”	Diligence. Data, disclosure, approval — decided before.
“Every answer was correct, so the agent works.”	Performance discernment. Check outcomes across many users.
“Agency is the most advanced — always use it.”	No mode is better. Match the mode to the task.

Unsure if it's fair? Ask who's affected, what could go wrong, what fair looks like, what to disclose — **answer and document, or escalate.** The test: **“Would I put my name on this?”**

Mostly D1 · touches D2–D7

Give AI the job — then decide

Asking → an answer. The work stays with you.

Giving a job → a result. You keep the checking.

YOURS		AI WORKS · YOU WATCH		YOURS	
1 Define	2 Delegate	3 Observe	4 Intervene	5 Verify	6 Accept

THE DELEGATION BRIEF — six lines before AI starts

Outcome — what should exist	**Context** — what AI can't know	**Constraints** — the limits
Authority — what it may decide alone	**Deliverable** — the usable form	**Verification** — what you'll check

Orange = the two lines people skip. A thinking tool, not a form.

Outcome, not clicks — a step-by-step recipe caps the result at your own plan. **Need first, then tool** — use a control only when the job needs it.

What the job needs → what you do → how you check

The job needs…	So you…	And you check…
Current facts	Make it search; ask “searched or already knew?”	No source → don't assume it looked. A source isn't a date.
A source only you have	“Use only this text” + “quote the sentence”	Find the quote word for word. “Not in the source” is a good answer.
Something private	Strip names & numbers first; temporary / incognito chat	Incognito isn't deletion — the provider still keeps a copy.
A finished thing	Ask for the deliverable — table, document, file	Count caveats before and after. Tidy documents drop “unverified”.
The same job again	2nd time: save the brief. 3rd time: put it in a Project	Sources → knowledge · rules → standing instructions. A repeated method → a Skill.

A citation is not verification. Checking the citation is. Open the page, find the sentence, check the date.

Set the limits — then fix drift with the smallest move

Face 1 · the method

Plan-first: “List your steps and wait for my go.” Change one step.
Before the run is the cheapest fix.

Face 2 · the actions

Research, don't **buy**	Draft, don't **send**
Inspect, don't **delete**	Choose, but **say so**

In a chat: habits. Once AI can act: permissions.

The failure is the silent change — a better route is fine if it tells you.

What you see	The move
Answered a different question	Stop — restate the outcome
One fact or line is wrong	Correct — name it + replacement
Heading the wrong way	Redirect — name the direction
The job itself was wrong	Change the requirement, say so
Can't do it at this level	Escalate — thinking, stronger model, or smaller steps
Still failing after that	Take it back — some jobs are yours

Check the fix in the result, not in “I've corrected it.” Then write the lesson into the brief so it doesn't happen again.

Verify, then decide — the name on it is yours

Identify the claims that matter → **Trace** to the sentence + date → **Challenge** — how could it be wrong? → **Decide:** accept · correct · investigate · reject

The bait	Why it's wrong — and the right move
“It cited a page, so it's verified.”	Open it. Page says something slightly different → correct or investigate.
“A detailed step-by-step recipe is safer.”	It caps the result at your plan. Describe the outcome instead.
“It says it fixed the table.”	A sentence, not an event. Look at the table.
“I approved the plan, so any change is fine.”	Changes are fine; silent changes aren't. Compare plan to run.
“It failed — AI can't do this job.”	Maybe the wrong level. Escalate first; take it back last.
“Two AIs differed — rank the better one.”	It's a record of two runs, not a ranking. The brief should travel unchanged.

AI doing the work does not transfer accountability to AI. Safest first delegation: a job you've already finished and trust.

A scheduled run that *ran* isn't one that *worked*. Keep a Delegation Record: brief → run → check → decision.